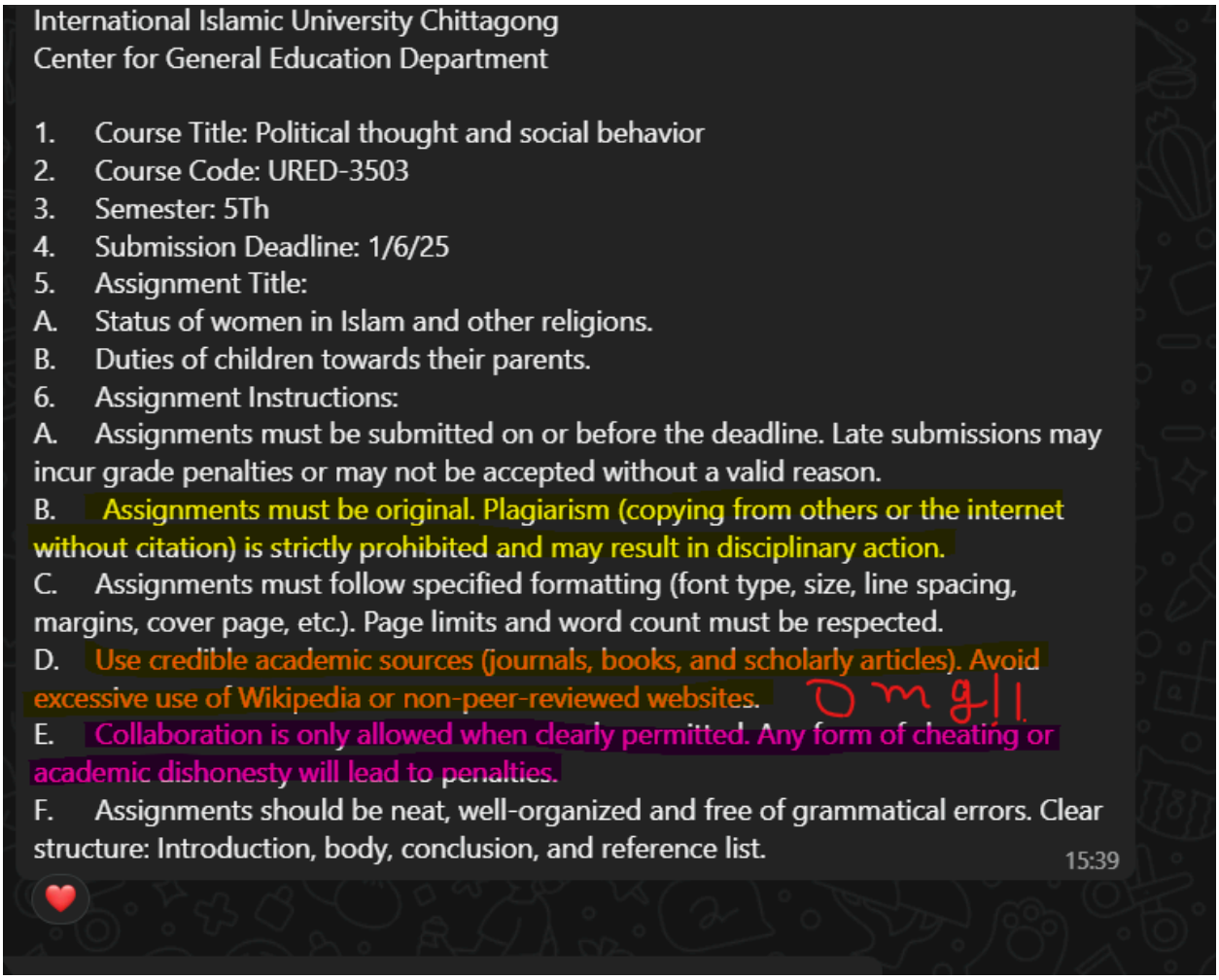


Status of women in Islam and other religions

Women hold a highly respected and dignified position in Islamic society. Unlike many other historical civilizations and religious traditions, Islam uplifted the status of women, granting them rights, respect, and responsibilities. The role of a woman as a mother, daughter, sister, and wife is clearly defined and honored in the teachings of Islam.

The Prophet Muhammad (peace and blessings be upon him) emphasized the importance of women in many of his sayings. In one Hadith, he said:

> **“Paradise lies at the feet of your mother.”**
> — *Sunan an-Nasa’i, Book 25, Hadith 3104*

On another occasion, a man came to the Prophet (ﷺ) and asked:

> **“O Messenger of Allah, who among the people is the most worthy of my good companionship?”**
> He replied: **“Your mother.”**
> The man asked again, “Then who?”
> The Prophet said: **“Your mother.”**
> He asked a third time, “Then who?”
> The Prophet again replied: **“Your mother.”**
> When he asked a fourth time, the Prophet said: **“Then your father.”**
> — *Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim*

In his final sermon at ‘Arafah during the Farewell Pilgrimage, Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) addressed the rights of women:

> **“O People! Your wives have a right over you, and you have a right over them... Treat them kindly, for they are your partners and committed helpers.”**

The Prophet also stated:

> **“The best of you is the one who is best to his wife.”**
> — *Sunan Ibn Majah, Book 9, Hadith 1977*

These statements clearly reflect the honorable and equal treatment of women in Islam, countering many modern misconceptions, especially

in Western narratives, that portray Muslim women as oppressed or deprived of their rights.

In fact, Islamic history gives prominence to women in both spiritual and societal roles. One powerful example is from the Hajj pilgrimage: one of the rites includes walking between the hills of Safa and Marwa, which commemorates the act of **Hajar (Hagar)**, the mother of Prophet Isma'il (peace be upon him), who ran between these hills in search of water for her son. This act, by a woman, is forever memorialized in a key pillar of Islamic worship.

The Quran on the Status of Women

The Qur'an acknowledges the dignity, rights, and responsibilities of women. Allah says:

> **"And for women are rights similar to those of men over them in kindness…"**
> — *Surah Al-Baqarah (2:228)*

> **"Indeed, the Muslim men and Muslim women, the believing men and believing women... Allah has prepared for them forgiveness and a great reward."**
> — *Surah Al-Ahzab (33:35)*

These verses show that both men and women are spiritually equal and accountable before Allah, and both have been promised reward for their righteousness.

Comparison with Other Societies:

To understand how Islam elevated women, it is helpful to examine their treatment in other historical societies:

- In **ancient Rome**, women were treated as property and had very limited legal rights.

- Among the **Greeks**, women were often seen as inferior beings, not even allowed to participate in political or intellectual life.

- In **early Christianity**, women were considered the root of evil, with Eve being blamed for the fall of Adam.

- In **India**, practices such as **Sati** (widow-burning) and viewing women as impure were common.

- **Pre-Islamic Arab society** saw the birth of a daughter as a disgrace; some tribes even buried baby girls alive.

> **"And when the girl [who was] buried alive is asked. For what sin she was killed."**
> — *Surah At-Takwir (81:8-9)*

Islam came as a liberation for women, prohibiting such inhumane practices and restoring their dignity and rights.

Even in the modern West, women struggled for centuries to obtain basic rights. In **France**, a council in 587 CE debated whether women were even human beings. In **England**, women were not recognized as citizens until the mid-19th century. Even prestigious universities like **Oxford and Cambridge** did not offer equal rights to female students until the 1960s.

<u>Islamic Perspective on Equality:</u>

Islam acknowledges the biological and psychological differences between men and women and prescribes duties accordingly. However, it does **not** consider one superior to the other in terms of humanity or piety:

> **"Whoever does righteousness, whether male or female, while being a believer – We will surely cause them to live**

a good life and We will surely give them their reward according to the best of what they used to do."
— Surah An-Nahl (16:97)

Islam does not promote total gender uniformity, but rather complementary roles. These defined roles ensure social harmony and family stability. The pursuit of absolute equality in every domain, as witnessed in some modern societies, has led to problems like the breakdown of family structures, rise in teenage pregnancies, and weakening of moral values.

Conclusion:

Islam granted women respect, dignity, and rights long before any modern movement advocated for them. The roles and rights assigned to women are in harmony with their nature and aimed at preserving the fabric of a healthy society. When compared to the treatment of women in past civilizations and even parts of the modern world, Islam stands out as a progressive, balanced, and humane system that truly honors women .

Duties of children towards their parents

Islam recognizes the family as a foundational unit of society. Among the most vital relationships in this unit is the parent-child relationship. To maintain this bond, both parents and children have mutual rights and responsibilities. The rights of one party are the duties of the other, and this reciprocity is essential for harmony in family life.

Importance of Parents in Islam

After Allah (SWT), parents are the greatest benefactors of a person. From the moment of birth, parents provide care, protection, sustenance, love, and education. The mother endures hardship during pregnancy, faces the pain of childbirth, and sacrifices her comfort for her children. The father works tirelessly to provide for the family's physical, emotional, and spiritual well-being.

It is natural to express gratitude to someone who does us a favor. If a stranger helps us, we feel indebted and thank them. Our parents do far more, so it is our **duty to be grateful** to them and serve them kindly.

Qur'anic Command on Gratitude to Parents

Allah (SWT) commands in the Qur'an:

> **وَقَضَىٰ رَبُّكَ أَلَّا تَعْبُدُوا إِلَّا إِيَّاهُ وَبِالْوَالِدَيْنِ إِحْسَانًا ۚ**
> *"Your Lord has decreed that you worship none but Him, and that you be kind to your parents…"*
> (Surah Al-Isra, 17:23)

This ayah makes it clear that **kindness to parents is a divine** command, directly following the command to worship Allah alone.

Demonstrating Kindness and Obedience to Parents

Being good to parents includes:

- Obeying them in lawful matters
- Speaking to them with **gentle words and a soft tone**
- Avoiding arguments and disrespect
- Giving them company, especially in old age
- Fulfilling their physical, emotional, and financial needs
- Praying for them

> **وَاخْفِضْ لَهُمَا جَنَاحَ الذُّلِّ مِنَ الرَّحْمَةِ وَقُل رَّبِّ ارْحَمْهُمَا كَمَا رَبَّيَانِي صَغِيرًا**
> *"And lower to them the wing of humility out of mercy and say: 'My Lord, have mercy upon them as they brought me up [when I was] small.'"*
> (Surah Al-Isra, 17:24)

Status of the Mother in Islam

The **mother holds a position of superior respect** due to the pain and sacrifice she endures. The Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) emphasized this in a famous hadith:

> A companion asked: "O Messenger of Allah, who is most deserving of my good company?"
> He said: "**Your mother.**"

He asked: “Then who?”
The Prophet said: “**Your mother.**”
He asked again: “Then who?”
The Prophet said: “**Your mother.**”
He asked: “Then who?”
The Prophet replied: “**Your father.**”
(Sahih Bukhari & Muslim)

Another hadith says:

> **"Paradise lies under the feet of the mother."**
> This means serving and honoring one's mother can lead a person to Paradise.

Story from Hadith: A Lesson on Serving Parents

The Prophet (PBUH) told a story of three men trapped in a cave due to a landslide. Each one prayed to Allah by mentioning a good deed they had done. One of them said:

> *“One night I brought milk for my parents, but they were asleep. I did not wake them and stood by their bedside the whole night holding the milk until they awoke.”*

Because of this sincere act of kindness to his parents, Allah caused the rock to move, and eventually all three were saved. (Sahih Bukhari)

Summary of the Duties of Children (Rights of Parents)

(a) Right to be Respected and Obeyed

Parents deserve to be listened to and obeyed. They act in the best interests of their children, even when children may not realize it. Disobedience and rudeness are sins in Islam.

> **وَبِالْوَالِدَيْنِ إِحْسَانًا**
> *"And be good to your parents."*
> (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:83)

(b) Right to Correct Their Children

Parents have the right to advise, scold, or even rebuke their children if they go astray. Children must bear this with patience and humility, knowing it comes from a place of love.

(c) Right to be Cared for

As children grow into adulthood, it becomes their duty to take care of their parents, especially in their old age, providing for their physical and financial needs.

> **قُلْ مَا أَنفَقْتُم مِّنْ خَيْرٍ فَلِلْوَالِدَيْنِ**
> *"Say: Whatever of your wealth you spend shall be for parents…"*
> (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:215)

(d) Right to Receive Help

Children should assist parents in household work. Sons can help with heavy tasks; daughters can help in chores like cooking and cleaning. A good child helps **without being asked**.

(e) Right to Kind Words and Behavior

Kind speech and behavior are essential. Even if parents are wrong, children should not raise their voices or speak disrespectfully.

A Warning from Modern Society

In many Western societies, family values have weakened. Children often disobey their parents, and elderly parents are left alone in senior homes. Islam warns against such behavior and emphasizes **strong family bonds** and **respect for elders**.

Conclusion

The duties of children in Islam are clearly defined. Gratitude, obedience, love, and service to parents are not only social values but divine commands. Serving parents brings **worldly blessings and eternal reward**. Islam, like all divine religions, places great emphasis on honoring parents.